TRADE'S NEW MAP

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From African ports to Asian highways, new trade routes are quietly rewriting the rules of global commerce. The weaponisation of tariffs by the West, most recently under Donald Trump's renewed trade measures, has pushed developing nations to find growth beyond Western approval. Instead of waiting for access to old markets, countries across the Global South are opening new pathways, building connections across Africa, the Middle East, Asia, and Latin America.

South–South trade

The BRICS alliance sits at the centre of this shift. Together, its members represent over 40% of global GDP and nearly one-third of world trade, according to the IMF. But their power lies not just in numbers; it lies in networks. South–South trade has more than tripled since 2000, now exceeding $5 trillion annually, driven by partnerships that blur old geographic and political boundaries.

Brazil's agricultural exports to Africa have climbed by over 25% in the past five years, India's digital and pharmaceutical sectors are expanding across the continent, and China continues to finance over 60 major ports, rail, and energy projects in Africa alone. These are not acts of aid, they're acts of alignment, building a web of interdependence across emerging markets.

Africa's trade awakening

The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), the world's largest free trade zone by membership, aims to connect 1.4 billion people across 55 nations. According to the UN Economic Commission for Africa, AfCFTA could boost intra-African trade by more than 50% by 2030, cutting tariffs and simplifying customs procedures.

The AfCTFA is about more than moving goods; it's about driving value. It is rooted in turning African raw materials into African wealth. Think of Ghanaian cocoa processed into chocolate in Côte d'Ivoire, or Ethiopian textiles stitched from local cotton and sold across the continent. Every new trade route becomes a thread in a larger fabric of self-determination.

On the ground, trade corridors are the arteries of this change. The Lamu Port–South Sudan–Ethiopia Transport (LAPSSET) corridor, the North–South Corridor from Durban to Lusaka, and the Central Corridor through Tanzania are turning once-landlocked economies into regional hubs. The BRICS New Development Bank (NDB) has already committed more than $30 billion to such infrastructure, roads, ports, and railways, helping build the literal foundations of a new economic geography.

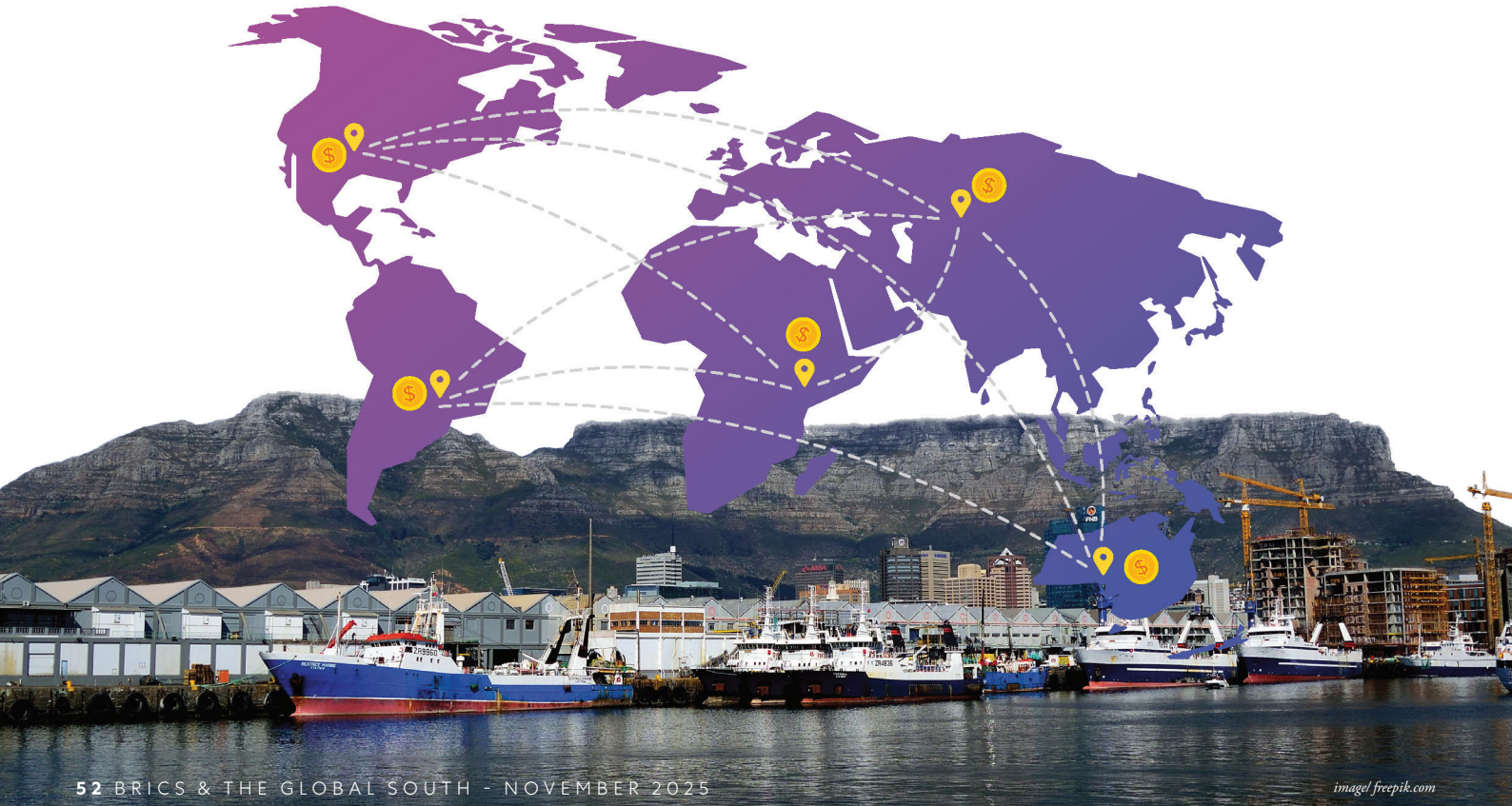
From dependency to design

For much of the post-colonial era, global trade resembled a one-way street. Raw materials flowing out of the Global South and finished goods for the North flowing back in. Tariffs and sanctions were used to maintain this hierarchy. But as Western economies slow and protectionism rises under the banner of "national security," the South is shifting from dependency to design.

Of course, challenges remain with fragmented customs systems, infrastructure gaps, and the need to ensure that small businesses share in the gains, but the groundwork has been laid. With AfCFTA advancing, BRICS expanding, and regional supply chains strengthening, the next chapter of trade is already being drafted, not in Washington or Brussels, but in Nairobi, São Paulo, Mumbai, and Shanghai.

A world rewired

Tariffs may have been weaponised, but the Global South is no longer playing defence. It's building resilience, one corridor, one partnership, and one port at a time. What's emerging is not just a new trade network, but a new philosophy of globalisation, one built on cooperation rather than control, and on shared prosperity rather than inherited privilege.



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